

Hand impressions and armed horsemen painted on the ceiling and walls of the same cave, the latter probably dating from about 800 BCE.

Dr Wakankar and his colleagues identified five stages in the development of this rock art, beginning with simple representations of bison, rhinoceroses, tigers and elephants in green and red pigment, moving on to hunting and domestic scenes such as dancing, and ending with the appearance of horsemen armed with swords and spears drawn in white or yellow pigment. Extravagant claims have been made for the dating of Bhimbetka, but I shall stick with the line taken by UNESCO, which states that its rock-shelters contain paintings ‘that appear to date from the Mesolithic period right through to the historical period’.

That term Mesolithic refers to the period between the Palaeolithic, when humans were purely hunter-gatherers using chipped stone tools, and the Neolithic, when they first began to plant crops, herd animals and use polished stone tools, so its dating varies from place to place. Very few characteristically Mesolithic sites have so far been found in India, although we should bear in mind that many sites along coastal plains would have been lost to the sea after the ending of the last ice age. Even so, this paucity rather suggests that the majority human population inhabiting